ANSWER KEY & MARKING SCHEME — ENGLISH LANGUAGE AND LITERATURE · CLASS X · SET 02

Max. Marks: 80 · Alternative correct answers / expressions to be given due credit · Writing: Format 1 + Content 2 + Fluency & accuracy 2

SECTION A — READING SKILLS — 20 marks

1. Read the following passage. **10**

1. Long before taps and pipelines reached our homes, the people of India's dry regions had found an ingenious way to store water: the stepwell. Known as a baoli in the north and a vav in Gujarat, a stepwell is a deep well with flights of steps leading down to the water. Hundreds of them were built across Rajasthan, Gujarat and neighbouring states over many centuries. Rani ki Vav at Patan, honoured as a World Heritage Site in 2014, and the Chand Baori at Abhaneri, with its dizzying pattern of steps, are two of the finest examples.

2. The steps were no mere decoration. In regions where rainfall is scarce and uncertain, the level of water in a well changes with the seasons. A person could walk down the steps to reach the water when it was low and need only a few steps when the monsoon had filled the well. The steps also allowed people, cattle and travelling merchants to use the water directly without ropes and buckets. Pillared pavilions and shaded corridors beside the water offered travellers a cool place to rest in the blazing summer.

3. Stepwells were also centres of community life. Women gathered there each day to draw water and exchange news, festivals were celebrated beside them, and small shrines were often built at their edges. Skilled craftsmen carved gods, dancers and patterns on the walls, which shows that the builders cared about beauty as much as usefulness. At the same time, the wells played a quiet environmental role. By collecting monsoon run-off and letting it sink slowly into the ground, they helped to recharge groundwater.

4. This careful system declined under changing conditions. During the colonial period, piped water was introduced in many towns and stepwells came to be regarded as unhygienic. After independence, hand pumps and tube wells replaced them even in villages. Without regular use, the wells were neglected; some were filled with garbage and rubble, while others dried up as the groundwater fell. Over time, many people forgot that these structures had ever been the lifeline of entire villages, and the knowledge of how to maintain them slowly disappeared along with the craftsmen who built them.

5. In recent years, however, local communities, heritage experts and conservation agencies have begun to clean and repair these monuments. Some restored stepwells now supply water again and help to collect rainwater in nearby fields. These efforts remind us that sustainable answers to scarcity often lie in local knowledge. By valuing our stepwells, we protect an inheritance of art, engineering and wisdom that our water-stressed age badly needs.

Created for academic usage / 428 words

Answer the following questions, based on the passage above.

I. Why were stepwells built with flights of steps instead of a simple well with a rope and bucket? (Paragraph 2) **1**

> Because the water level changed with the seasons; steps let people reach the water whether it was low or high.

II. According to Paragraphs 2 and 3, stepwells served all of the following purposes EXCEPT **1**

(A) resting places for travellers
(B) centres of community gatherings
(C) recharging of groundwater
(D) storage of grain for the winter

> **Ans: (D)** Nothing is said about storing grain.

III. Complete the following by selecting the correct option from those given in the brackets: The carved walls of stepwells show that they were designed not only as _____ structures but also as works **1**

of art. (functional / ornamental) (Paragraph 3)

> functional

IV. Select the option that is TRUE for what the word 'neglected' suggests in Paragraph 4. **1**

(A) The stepwells were closely guarded.
(B) The stepwells received no regular care after they went out of use.
(C) The stepwells were rebuilt with modern material.
(D) The stepwells were demolished by the government.

> **Ans: (B)** The stepwells received no regular care after they went out of use.

V. Complete the analogy by selecting the correct option. **1**

Granary : Grain storage :: Stepwell : _____

(A) Water storage
(B) Power generation

> **Ans: (A)** Water storage.

VI. How did stepwells help in recharging groundwater? (Paragraph 3) **2**

> They collected monsoon run-off (1) and let the water sink slowly into the soil, which raised the groundwater level (1).

VII. What are the main ideas of Paragraph 4 and Paragraph 5? **1**

i. Colonial and modern water systems led to neglect of stepwells.
ii. Communities and experts are now restoring stepwells and their lessons.
iii. Stepwells were always unhygienic.
iv. Tube wells are better than stepwells.
v. Stepwells cannot be revived.

Option	Main idea of Paragraph 4	Main idea of Paragraph 5
A	iii	v
B	ii	i
C	i	ii
D	iv	iii

> **Ans: (C)** Paragraph 4 — i; Paragraph 5 — ii.

VIII. Why does the author say that stepwells hold lessons for today's 'water-stressed age'? (Paragraph 5) **2**

> They show that local, low-cost methods of harvesting and storing rainwater work in dry regions (1); reviving them can help meet today's water scarcity (1).

2. Read the following passage. **10**

1. A survey of 500 students from Classes 9 to 12 explored how they use their school library. The results show a promising picture. About 64% of the students (320) visit the library at least once a week, and 40% (200) regularly borrow storybooks for pleasure. However, only 27% (135) read newspapers or magazines there, and 58% (290) said that they prefer e-books to printed books while studying.

2. The study also compared reading habits with academic performance. Among the 200 students who borrow storybooks, 160 students (80%) scored above the class average in English. In comparison, only 120 of the remaining 300 students (40%) did so. The researchers caution that reading alone may not explain the difference, but they note that wide reading improves vocabulary, imagination and understanding of long passages. Librarians add that students who read widely also tend to ask better questions in class and to express their ideas with greater clarity in both speech and writing.

3. Teachers suggest that libraries should keep a mix of print and digital resources, organise book clubs and display new arrivals prominently. When students find reading enjoyable rather than compulsory, they build a habit that

serves them well beyond school. The survey also found that 45% of the students (225) would visit more often if the library stayed open after school hours, a demand that schools could meet with little extra cost.

Created for academic usage / 229 words

Answer the following questions, based on the passage above.

I. Why does the first paragraph present the survey results as 'promising'? (Paragraph 1) **1**

> Because most students (64%) visit the library weekly and many borrow storybooks.

II. Complete the following by selecting the correct option from those given in the brackets. Only 135 of the 500 students read newspapers in the library, which suggests that newspaper reading is _____ . (popular / limited) (Paragraph 1) **1**

> limited

III. Select the option that best explains the expression 'above the class average' in Paragraph 2. **1**

(A) Lower than most students
(B) Better than the typical score of the class
(C) Equal to the topper
(D) The highest score in school

> **Ans: (B)** Better than the typical score of the class.

IV. Complete the following with the correct option. The percentages 80% and 40% in Paragraph 2 suggest that **1**

(A) storybooks harm performance.
(B) students who borrow storybooks tended to perform better in English.
(C) only toppers visit the library.
(D) newspapers improve English.

> **Ans: (B)** students who borrow storybooks tended to perform better in English.

V. Complete the analogy by selecting the correct option. **1**
Library : Books :: Reading club : _____

(A) Discussion of books
(B) Sports equipment

> **Ans: (A)** Discussion of books.

VI. Complete the following appropriately. The 58% of students who prefer e-books for studying indicate that libraries should also provide _____. (Paragraph 1) **1**

> digital resources / e-books and internet access.

VII. Why do the researchers caution that reading alone may not explain the difference in performance? (Paragraph 2) **1**

> Because other factors such as teaching, effort and background may also influence marks.

VIII. What benefits of wide reading are mentioned in Paragraph 2? **1**

> Better vocabulary, imagination and understanding of long passages.

IX. How can schools make reading 'enjoyable rather than compulsory'? Explain how this helps students in later life. (Paragraph 3) **2**

> By book clubs, displays of new arrivals and a mix of print and digital resources (1); students form a lifelong habit of reading that supports learning and career growth (1).

SECTION B — GRAMMAR AND WRITING SKILLS — 20 marks

GRAMMAR — 10

3. Complete any ten of the twelve of the following tasks, as directed. **(10 × 1 = 10)**

I. Fill in the blank by using the correct form of the word in the bracket for the given portion of a school notice: **1**

The announcement was received with great _____ (excite) by the entire school.

> excitement

II. Identify the error and write the correction in the given sentence. **1**

I have been living in this colony since five years.

ERROR	CORRECTION

> Error: since — Correction: for (a period of time).

III. Fill in the blank with the correct form of verb given in the brackets. **1**

If the bus _____ (arrive) on time, we would have reached the venue before the speech began.

> had arrived

IV. Read the given statement. **1**

Mother said to me, “You must finish your project today.”

Report it correctly by completing the following.

Mother told me that _____.

> I must / had to finish my project that day.

V. Fill in the blank by choosing the correct option. **1**

He is very fond _____ collecting old coins.

(A) of
(B) for
(C) with
(D) at

> **Ans: (A)** fond of

VI. Report the following by completing the sentence correctly. **1**

“Don't touch the wires,” the electrician warned the children.

The electrician warned _____.

> the children not to touch the wires.

VII. Complete the given sentence by filling the blank with the correct option. **1**

She avoided _____ the question during the interview.

(A) answer
(B) to answer
(C) answering
(D) answered

> **Ans: (C)** avoid + gerund.

VIII. The given sentence has an error. Select the option that correctly identifies the error and the correction. **1**

The teacher as well as the students were present at the function.

No.	Error	Correction
A.	teacher	teachers
B.	were	was

C.	present	presents
D.	function	functions

Ans: (B) With ‘as well as’ the verb agrees with the first subject (teacher): were → was.

IX. Report the following question. **1**
“Do you know the way to the station?” the tourist asked me.

The tourist asked me if/whether I knew the way to the station.

X. Fill in the blank with the correct option from those given in the brackets. **1**
You _____ (must / used to) wear a helmet while riding a two-wheeler; it is the law.

must

XI. Fill in the blank to complete the sentence in a shopkeeper's note by choosing the correct option. **1**
There is very _____ milk left in the jug, so we need to buy some more.

(A) few
(B) little
(C) many
(D) several

Ans: (B) ‘little’ is used with uncountable nouns.

XII. Identify the error and write the correction in the given sentence. **1**
Each of the players have received a medal.

ERROR	CORRECTION

Error: have — Correction: has (each takes a singular verb).

4. Attempt ANY ONE from A and B. **1 × 5 = 5**

A. You are Aarav/Aarushi, Head Boy/Head Girl of Sunrise Public School. Many students find that the school library closes too early to prepare for the approaching board examinations. Write a letter to the Principal, in about 120 words, requesting that library hours be extended and explaining how it will help students.

Format (1), Content (2), Fluency (2). Points: need for self-study, crowded homes, extended hours till 6 p.m., librarian arrangement, benefit.
Sample: The Principal, Sunrise Public School, Jaipur / Subject: Request for extending library hours. Respected Madam, I am writing on behalf of Class X students to request that the library be kept open until 6 p.m. during the examination period. At present it closes at 2.30 p.m., leaving most of us with no quiet place to study. Many of us live in small, crowded homes, and access to reference books and previous papers would greatly improve our preparation. We are ready to follow all library rules and to share responsibility for discipline. We believe that the extra hours will help us manage our time better and perform with confidence. Thanking you, Yours obediently, Aarav Singh, Head Boy.

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B. You are Meera/Manav, a citizen concerned about the large-scale use of plastic bags in your local vegetable market. Write a letter to the Editor of a national daily, in about 120 words, highlighting the harm caused by plastic and suggesting practical alternatives.

Format (1), Content (2), Fluency (2). Points: plastic choking drains, harming cattle, non-biodegradable; alternatives — cloth/jute bags, paper packets, fines, awareness drive.
Sample: The Editor, The Morning Herald, New Delhi / Subject: Plastic menace in our markets. Sir, I wish to draw public attention to the unchecked use of plastic bags in our vegetable market. Discarded bags choke drains, cause waterlogging and are swallowed by stray cattle, often with fatal results. Since plastic does not decompose, it also pollutes the soil for years. The ban is rarely enforced. I suggest that shopkeepers offer jute or cloth bags, customers carry their own, and the municipality impose fines on offenders. Schools and resident groups can run awareness drives. Such steps will make our markets cleaner and our environment safer. Yours truly, Meera Joshi.

5. Attempt ANY ONE from A and B. **1 × 5 = 5**

A. Mrs Rao, the Science teacher, has to choose a team leader for the school science exhibition. **Sanya:** creative, designs excellent models and explains concepts clearly, but she starts late and often needs reminders about deadlines. **Ishaan:** organised and punctual, always submits work on time, but his ideas are conventional and he is not comfortable speaking to visitors. Based on the profiles, analyse and decide who would be the better leader. Consider teamwork, creativity, time management and communication. (100–120 words)

> **Content (2), Organisation (1), Fluency (2).** Either choice acceptable if reasoned.
> *Sample:* Sanya would make the better leader of the team. An exhibition succeeds when ideas are original and clearly presented, and Sanya's creativity and gift for explanation directly serve this purpose. Her weakness is poor time management, but that can be overcome by pairing her with Ishaan, whose punctuality and discipline would keep the project on schedule. Ishaan, though dependable, is uncomfortable with visitors and offers few new ideas, which limits his ability to inspire the team. A leader must motivate and represent the group, and Sanya is the better fit. With Ishaan as the deputy in charge of deadlines, the two skill sets would complement each other and produce an excellent exhibition.

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B. The table compares two trekking packages offered by tour operators.

Features	Package A	Package B
Cost per person	₹6,500	₹9,800
Duration	3 days	5 days
Difficulty level	Easy	Moderate
Group size	Up to 30	Up to 12
Trained guide	1 for the group	1 for every 6 trekkers

Study the data and write an analytical paragraph in about 100–120 words comparing the two packages, identifying their strengths and limitations and suggesting which is better for a school group, with reasons.

> **Content (2), Analysis/recommendation (1), Fluency (2).**
> *Sample:* Package A is cheaper at ₹6,500 and shorter, with an easy trail, which suits beginners and limited budgets. However, one guide for up to thirty trekkers raises safety concerns. Package B costs ₹9,800 and lasts five days over a moderate trail, but its small groups and one guide for every six trekkers ensure better supervision and attention. For a school group, safety is the first priority. Although Package B is costlier and more demanding, its guide ratio is a decisive advantage. If the group is young or inexperienced, the school could choose Package A only if extra teachers accompany the students. On balance, Package B is the better choice for safety, while A remains the budget option.

SECTION C — LITERATURE TEXTBOOK — 40 marks

6. Read the following extracts and answer the questions for any one of the given two, (a) or (b). **5**

(a)

> *Anne writes that paper has more patience than people. When she sits down to write to her diary, she feels that she can say whatever she likes without fear of being laughed at or scolded. She has decided to treat the diary as a close friend and give it a name, because what she wants is a friend to whom she can pour out her heart.*
> (From the Diary of Anne Frank — extract adapted)

I. What does Anne feel about 'paper'? **1**

(A) It is costly
(B) It is more patient than people
(C) It is difficult to use
(D) It is wasteful

> **Ans: (B)** It is more patient than people.

II. State one inference about Anne's relationships with the people around her. **1**

She does not have anyone to confide in / feels misunderstood.

III. Complete suitably. Giving the diary a name shows Anne's wish for _____. **1**

(A) fame
(B) friendship
(C) money
(D) revenge

Ans: (B) friendship / companionship.

IV. How does the diary offer Anne the freedom she lacks in hiding? Answer in about 40 words. **2**

In hiding she cannot speak or move freely (1); the diary lets her express every thought honestly without fear of judgment (1).

O R

(b)

Valli stood by the roadside every day to watch the bus roar past in a cloud of dust. She imagined herself seated by the window, watching the fields and houses fly by like a grown-up lady. Though she was only a small girl, she saved every coin she could, determined to turn her daydream into a real journey.

(Madam Rides the Bus — extract adapted)

I. What did Valli watch every day? **1**

(A) The train
(B) The bus passing by
(C) A fair
(D) Her school

Ans: (B) The bus passing by.

II. What does the phrase 'saved every coin she could' tell us about Valli? **1**

She is determined and resourceful.

III. Complete suitably. Valli imagined herself as a _____. **1**

(A) school teacher
(B) grown-up lady
(C) bus driver
(D) village leader

Ans: (B) grown-up lady.

IV. How does the extract bring out Valli's strong desire for independence? Answer in about 40 words. **2**

She dreams of travelling like an adult (1); saving coins shows she is willing to work towards her goal (1).

7. Read the following extracts and answer the questions for any one of the given two, (a) or (b). **5**

(a)

The poet imagines that the trees, which have been kept in the room, have been pushing against the window all night. Their leaves strain towards the open air, and it seems that they are about to leave the house and walk back into the forest where they belong. The poem suggests that the trees long for freedom.

(The Trees — paraphrased)

I. Where have the trees been kept? **1**

(A) in the forest
(B) in the room
(C) in a garden
(D) in a farm

Ans: (B) In the room / the house.

II. What do the trees want to do? **1**

(A) to grow taller
(B) to return to the forest
(C) to be watered
(D) to be cut

> **Ans: (B)** To go back to the forest / be free.

III. The poem suggests that the trees stand for _____. **1**

(A) fear of man
(B) freedom and a longing to be natural
(C) human greed
(D) loneliness of the poet

> **Ans: (B)** freedom and a longing to be natural.

IV. How does the poet make the reader sympathise with the trees? Answer in about 40 words. **2**

> By describing them as straining towards the open window (1); personification makes their wish for freedom seem like a human desire (1).

O R

(b)

> *The fog arrives quietly, softly and without any noise, like a cat. It settles down for a while above the harbour and the city, looking over everything, and then moves on without announcing its departure.*
>
> (Fog — paraphrased)

I. What is the fog compared to? **1**

(A) a bird
(B) a cat
(C) a thief
(D) a wave

> **Ans: (B)** A cat.

II. What does 'moves on' suggest about the fog? **1**

> It is temporary and passes quickly.

III. The poem is written in the form of a _____. **1**

(A) story
(B) metaphor
(C) dialogue
(D) song

> **Ans: (B)** metaphor / extended comparison.

IV. How does the comparison make the fog seem alive? Answer in about 40 words. **2**

> The fog is given a cat's silent steps and sitting posture (1); this personification makes its arrival and departure seem gentle and deliberate (1).

8. Answer any four of the following five questions in 40–50 words each. **(4 × 3 = 12)**

I. How does the writer describe the people of Coorg in 'Glimpses of India' and what makes them unique? (Glimpses of India)

> They are brave, hospitable and proud of their martial tradition (1); Kodavus are known for their bravery in the army and for their hospitality (1); the land is rich in coffee, spices and green hills (1).

II. How does Ausable cleverly handle the situation with Max? (The Midnight Visitor)

He uses an invented story of police arriving to scare Max (1); he sounds calm and convincing (1); Max believes it and leaves in panic (1).

III. Why did Mrs Pumphrey's pampering harm Tricki? (A Triumph of Surgery)

She overfed him with sweets and rich food (1); he became fat and lazy (1); only a change of diet and exercise cured him (1).

IV. How does the black aeroplane help the pilot in 'Two Stories about Flying'? (Two Stories About Flying)

It appears when the pilot is lost in the storm and low on fuel (1); it guides him to land (1); later no such plane is found, giving the incident a mysterious touch (1).

V. Why does the proposal never take place peacefully in 'The Proposal'? (The Proposal)

Lomov and Natalya quarrel over land and their dogs (1); each wants to prove superiority (1); Chubukov's interference worsens it (1).

9. Answer any two of the following three questions in 40–50 words each. (2 × 3 = 6)

I. How does Ebright's mother help him become a scientist? (The Making of a Scientist)

She encouraged his curiosity and gave him books and materials (1); she allowed him to follow hobbies like butterfly collecting (1); this support built his confidence (1).

II. How does Horace Danby's trust in the woman prove costly? (A Question of Trust)

He trusted her story and believed her to be the owner (1); she used him to open the safe and took the jewels (1); his over-trust showed him as naive (1).

III. How does Kisa Gotami's grief lead to wisdom? (The Sermon at Benares)

She carries her dead son seeking medicine (1); the Buddha asks her for a mustard seed from a house untouched by death (1); she realises death is universal and cremates her son (1).

10. Answer ANY ONE of the following two questions, in about 100–120 words. (1 × 6)

(A) Anne Frank in hiding and the tiger in the zoo both live in confinement. Compare how each is affected by the loss of freedom. (From the Diary of Anne Frank / A Tiger in the Zoo)

Points: Anne is confined to the annexe, her diary becomes her outlet, she hopes; the tiger paces in his cage, 'quiet rage'; both long for freedom; Anne copes by writing, the tiger cannot; poet condemns captivity; both texts arouse sympathy. (2+2+2)

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(B) Valli in 'Madam Rides the Bus' and Bholi in 'Bholi' both grow in confidence through experience. Compare their journeys. (Madam Rides the Bus / Bholi)

Points: Valli's curiosity and ride; Bholi's education; both small, underestimated girls; Valli learns about life's harsh realities (dead cow), Bholi stands against injustice; both gain maturity. (2+2+2)

11. Answer ANY ONE of the following two questions, in about 100–120 words. (1 × 6)

(A) Discuss how Ausable's quick thinking in 'The Midnight Visitor' saves him from danger and what it shows about presence of mind. (The Midnight Visitor)

Points: Max enters with a gun; Ausable invents the police story; the balcony detail and the telephone call; Max flees; irony that Fowler thought him a spy-novel hero; presence of mind and bluff. (2+2+2)

O R

(B) 'A Triumph of Surgery' is an ironic title. Discuss how the story shows that overindulgence can be harmful and kindness must be balanced with sense. (A Triumph of Surgery)

Points: Tricki overfed; Mr Herriot's scheme — hospitalisation, diet and exercise; Mrs Pumphrey credits surgery; irony; humour; moral — love without discipline harms. (2+2+2)